AMERICAS UTILITIES: POWER

FERC largely rejects IRAS proposal; mixed for IPPs following CEG deals

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On October 9, FERC issued an order accepting in part and rejecting in part PJM's Interim Resource Adequacy Service (IRAS) proposal. FERC approved PJM's proposed definition of large load and the establishment of a large load registry effective October 12, 2026, but rejected the IRAS curtailment construct, Bring Your Own New Capacity (BYONC) rules, and the proposed exclusion of new large load from the Variable Resource Requirement (VRR) demand curve. While we see potential for the stocks to react modestly negative to the headline, we believe that the deals announced by CEG in the last couple of weeks have demonstrated that there are PPAs that can be finalized absent IRAS. In addition, fundamentals for PJM exposed IPPs continue to strengthen with pricing continuing to firm, which could lead to positive updates with 3Q results. Further, FERC's rejection of PJM's proposal to exclude any incremental new large loads from the VRR demand curve used in capacity auction forecasts, could pose upside risk to capacity prices longer term. We continue to see value in IPPs, where the stocks trade at an attractive discount across our coverage universe at ~8x EV/EBITDA and ~10% FCF yield on 2027 estimates (ex. CEG). We see Buy-rated TLN and Neutral-rated CEG as most directly levered to upside from PJM prices, followed by Buy rated NRG and VST.

Key takeaways from the decision. The FERC approved the IRAS proposal in part including 1) the definition of large load being any end-use customer with a peak demand of 50 MW+, and 2) the large load registry which is a centralized database requiring Load Serving Entities (LSE's) to report technical, operational, and locational data on qualifying large loads to enhance load forecasting. We include components of the proposal that FERC rejected below:

- **IRAS Curtailment Construct:** PJM proposed for utilities to curtail power to new data centers during early-stage grid emergencies if those facilities did not supply their own power plants. FERC rejected this element arguing that it cannot regulate retail electric service or tell local utilities which specific retail customers to disconnect. Furthermore, mandatory reliability standards prohibit cutting off paying firm transmission customers before voluntary demand response programs are exhausted.
- **Mandatory Capacity Matching Requirement:** PJM proposed requiring LSE's to procure new capacity equal to 100% of a new large customer's peak demand, or

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else face curtailment. FERC rejected this aspect noting PJM's capacity market is designed to procure sufficient power collectively for all firm network customers.

- **Bring Your Own New Capacity Accreditation**: The IRAS proposal allows data centers to bring new generation and freeze the resource's capacity reliability rating for 10 years so its capacity value could never be degraded. This aspect was rejected by the FERC on the basis of freezing accreditation would allow data centers to claim credit for power that does not actually exist, creating a hidden shortfall.
- **Excluding New Large Load from the VRR Capacity Demand Curve:** PJM proposed excluding new data center demand from the official capacity auction demand curve starting in Delivery Year 2029/2030 to prevent capacity auction price spikes for all customers in PJM on account of large load. FERC rejected this component as it would cause market distortion and cost mismatch.
- **The Separate Definition of New Large Load:** The IRAS proposal creates a separate regulatory category for large loads entering service after June 1, 2027 (or existing facilities adding load), specifically to isolate them for IRAS curtailment. This was denied on the basis that it had no standalone purpose given the rejection of the broader parts of the proposal were rejected.

Next steps. The FERC will codify the accepted large load definition and large load registry effective October 12, 2026. Next steps include PJM submitting a compliance filing within 30 days revising all provisions and references related to the definition of new large load, IRAS, BYONC, and VRR curve adjustments from its Tariff and RAA. Given PJM cannot exclude new large load from the VRR curve, PJM must model the full forecasted demand for the 2029/2030 BRA scheduled for December 2026, which should be supportive of pricing clearing at or near the cap. The FERC also states in its order that if PJM seeks to revive an emergency capacity mechanism, it should draft a new Section 205 filing that addresses FERC's comments, but would not take effect in time to be implemented for the upcoming auction. We also look for updates from PJM on whether it will file a separate Section 205 for the RBP process or if it will go through the paper hearing process.

Stock implications: While the regulatory overhang persists without a complete approval of the proposal, we believe the decision was broadly in-line with market expectations given the prior RBP suspension and the debate around IRAS when it was filed. Following CEG's PPA announcements, we believe there has been demonstration that some customers do not necessarily need the regulatory clarity from these processes to get deals across the finish line, where bilateral hybrid PPAs with merchant generators is the most commercially viable route to secure power. While we see potential for a modest negative reaction to the headline, we continue to see supportive fundamentals and attractive valuation for Buy rated IPPs including TLN, VST, and NRG, and we expect constructive 3Q earnings updates to potentially act as positive catalysts for shares, as well as persistent strong PJM capacity prices in the December auction following FERC's rejection of PJM's proposal to exclude large load.

Valuation and risks

TLN. We are Buy rated on TLN with a blended EV/EBITDA and FCF yield based valuation, and our 12-month price target of $509 reflects a target EV/EBITDA multiple of 9.5x and

FCF yield of 7.5%. Key downside risks for TLN include 1) Regulatory and interconnection risk, 2) lower than anticipated power prices, 3) slowdown in data center demand.

VST. We are Buy rated on VST with a blended EV/EBITDA and FCF yield based valuation, and our 12-month price target of $206 is based on an 10.0x EV/EBITDA multiple and a 7.0% FCF yield. Key downside risks for VST include: (1) PJM capacity auction uncertainty; (2) Lower-than-anticipated power prices; and (3) Future of the power demand theme.

NRG. We are Buy rated on NRG with a blended EV/EBITDA and FCF yield based valuation, and our 12-month price target of $169 is based on an 8.75x EV/EBITDA multiple and an 8.75% FCF yield. Key downside risks for NRG include: (1) Increased headline risk tied to AI and data center theme; (2) Lower-than-anticipated power prices; and (3) PJM capacity auction price uncertainty.

CEG. We are Neutral rated on CEG with a blended P/E and FCF yield based valuation, and our 12-month price target of $305 reflects a target P/E multiple of 21.0x and FCF yield of 5.0%. Key risks for CEG include 1) Regulatory and interconnection risk, 2) higher/lower than anticipated power prices, 3) increase/slowdown in data center demand.

Disclosure Appendix

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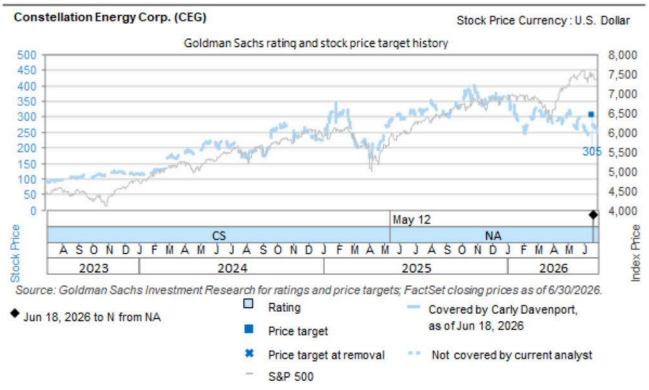
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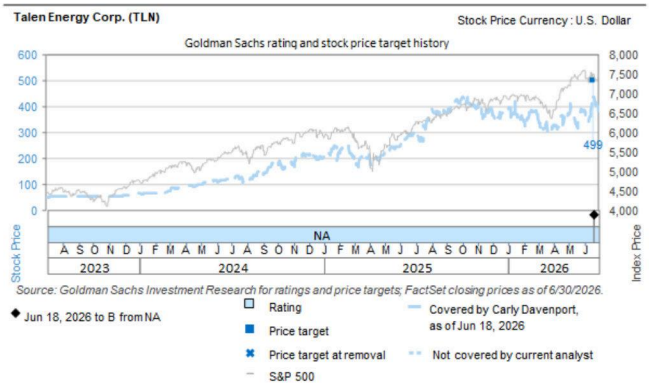
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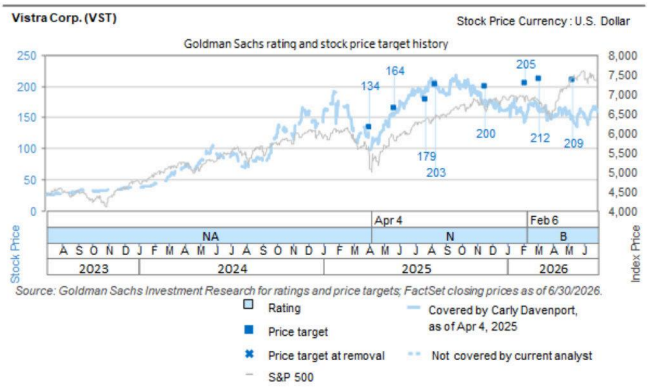
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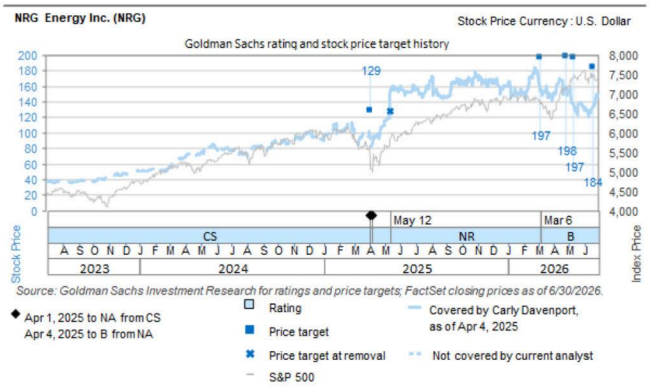
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Target price history table(s)

Vistra Corp. (VST)

Date of report	Target price ($)	Closing price ($)
11-Aug-26	206.00	144.92
12-May-26	209.00	146.87
06-Mar-26	212.00	158.65
06-Feb-26	205.00	149.65
19-Nov-25	200.00	179.14
12-Aug-25	203.00	209.56
24-Jul-25	179.00	196.24
23-May-25	164.00	158.16
04-Apr-25	134.00	98.07

NRG Energy Inc. (NRG)

Date of report	Target price ($)	Closing price ($)
05-Aug-26	169.00	120.73
18-Jun-26	184.00	135.06
12-May-26	197.00	137.34
27-Apr-26	198.00	160.15
06-Mar-26	197.00	154.32
04-Apr-25	129.00	83.61

Talen Energy Corp. (TLN)

Date of report	Target price ($)	Closing price ($)
10-Aug-26	509.00	343.19
18-Jun-26	499.00	436.29

Constellation Energy Corp. (CEG)

Date of report	Target price ($)	Closing price ($)
18-Jun-26	305.00	274.06

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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